XINYU ZHANG

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EDUCATION

University of Chicago *2024 – 2025*
M.A. in Social Sciences (MAPSS), Economics Concentration (Research Thesis Track) GPA: 3.96/4.00
Selected Coursework: Intro to Empirical Analysis; Optimization; Causal Inference; Econometrics and Machine Learning; Modern Methods for Applied Regression; PhD Math Camp

University of Chinese Academy of Social Sciences (UCASS) *2019 – 2024*
Bachelor of Economics Average: 91.5/100, **Rank: 1/56**
Academic Supervisor: Prof. Wenshu Gao
Selected Coursework: Calculus; Linear Algebra; Probability and Mathematical Statistics; Second Course in Statistics; Econometrics; Intermediate Micro-/Macroeconomics; Introduction to Advanced Microeconomics (PhD); Research Training in Economics; The Economics of Money, Banking, and Financial Markets

University of California, Berkeley *January 2022 – December 2022*
Berkeley International Study Program (Exchange) GPA: 3.96/4.00
Selected Coursework: Introduction to Analysis (Real Analysis); Linear Modeling; Upper-level Research Course; Graduate Statistics for Program Evaluation; Development Economics; Public Economics

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Household Finance; Corporate Finance; Development; Migration; Chinese Economy

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University *June 2025 – Present*
Empirical Research Fellow for Prof. Jacopo Ponticelli and Prof. Sean Higgins
Working on projects in corporate finance, structural transformation, behavioral finance, and political economy.

- *Data:* Cleaned and assembled large-scale administrative data, including 28 million loan-level rural credit records and several firm-level sales and transaction datasets; cleaned complex survey data from field experiments; digitalized and extracted data from historical records.
- *Research:* Implemented empirical analysis using proper methods and statistical tools, including causal inference, ML, and LLM; brainstormed with the PIs on ongoing projects and responses at the R&R stage.
- *Other responsibilities:* Prepared and validated replication packages for AEA journal publication; developed AI skills for a more rigorous research workflow.

Institute of Economics, Chinese Academy of Social Sciences *March 2021 – July 2023*
Research Assistant for Prof. Qunhui Huang, Prof. Wenshu Gao, and Prof. Chi Zhang

- *Input-Output Analysis and Income Inequality:* Built a dataset on China's domestic trade and labor markets from statistical yearbooks and web-scraped government sources; contributed to the identification strategy for estimating the effects of domestic factor reallocation and migration on income inequality across regions.
- *Frontiers Report on Political Economy (2022):* Collected literature and data; drafted the literature review.

RESEARCH PROJECTS

Can Personal Income Tax Cuts Encourage Marriage? *Working in Progress*
Supervised by Prof. Weiguang Deng & Prof. Srinivasan Vasudevan · Master's Thesis
Using data from the China Household Finance Survey and a regression discontinuity design, I find that personal income tax cuts significantly increase the probability of marriage among low-income women. By examining the consumption and loans of married individuals, I find that low-income groups are more likely to not understand Ricardian equivalence, thus increasing their current consumption.

Invisible Barriers: Gender Wage Gap among Domestic Migrants in China *Working Paper*
Undergraduate Thesis (UCASS) & Independent Study (Berkeley), supervised by Prof. Qiong Wang & Abdoulaye Cisse
Best Thesis Award; Best Paper Award at 4th National Development Economics Conference for Students
I estimate the gender wage gap among individuals in China who permanently migrated from rural to urban (*hukou* transition). Male migrants earn wages comparable to native urban men, while female migrants earn considerably less than their urban-native counterparts. I further document how the gap evolves with years since migration and how it varies across the income distribution.

Do International Students Promote China's Trade? *Unpublished Undergraduate Project*
National College Student Innovation and Entrepreneurship Training Program, supervised by Prof. Weiwei Wang
I identify the trade promotion effect of international students in China by a shift-share IV design, and show that the effect is driven mainly by self-funded students and students enrolled in elite training programs.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, UCASS: Undergraduate Econometrics (Prof. Qiong Wang), *Spring 2023*; Political Economy (Prof. Chi Zhang), *Fall 2021*

CONFERENCES AND WORKSHOPS

2026: Yale Predoc Conference
2025: MA Thesis Track Student Workshop (UChicago)
2024: MA Workshop (UChicago); National Development Economics Conference for Students (Sun Yat-sen University); Belt and Road Initiative Trade Students' Conference (Shanghai Finance and Economics)
2023: National Economics Students' Conference; Youth Forum on Development (both at Peking University)
2022: Upper-Level Research Course Selected Paper Presentation (Berkeley)

GRANTS, AWARDS, AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Gargoyle Research Scholarship and M.A. Director's Scholarship, UChicago (USD 6,000) *2024*
Best Paper Award at 4th National Development Economics Conference for Students (RMB 5,000) *2024*
Excellent Paper Award, Belt and Road Initiative Trade Students' Conference, SUFE *2024*
National College Student Innovation and Entrepreneurship Training Program Grant (RMB 20,000) *2023*
Finalist (Top 2%), Interdisciplinary Contest in Modeling (COMAP) *2022*
Undergraduate Research Grant, UCASS (RMB 4,000) *2021*
Outstanding Student Study Abroad Scholarship, UCASS (RMB 120,000 and RMB 50,000) *2021, 2024*
Academic Excellence Scholarship, UCASS *2020, 2021*
(rank 1st but not eligible due to exchange experience for 2023 and 2024 awards)

SERVICE AND OTHER ACTIVITIES

Camphor Economist Society, Education Content Creator (Excellent Creator Prize, 2023) *2021 – Present*
Graduate School Application Mentor, UCASS *2024 – Present*
Lanqiao Cup (Python Coding Track) Contest, Third Prize *2021, 2023*
TEDxDuolun Road, Sharing Economy and Regulations (15 min Presentation of a high school project) *2017*

SKILLS AND LANGUAGES

Programming: Stata and R (advanced); Python (intermediate); MATLAB, ArcGIS; LaTeX
Languages: Mandarin (native); English (proficient: TOEFL 5.5/6; Speaking 6/6); Spanish (beginning)

Last updated: October 2026 with language polished by AI